

EIYL Proposal

Ecological Question:

How do American crows (*Corvus brachyrhynchos*) in urban areas choose feeding sites, and how might human food waste availability influence their foraging behavior? I aim to investigate whether crows preferentially feed in areas with higher human activity (e.g., bus stops, outside dining areas, sidewalks near food courts) compared to more natural or less human-influenced spaces.

Observations / Research Plan:

I will make direct observations on campus (e.g., UBC Nest plaza, bus loop, and surrounding green spaces). During multiple short observation sessions at different times of day, I will record (1) crow presence/absence, (2) the number of crows present, and (3) the type of food sources available in the area (human food waste vs. natural food items like seeds/insects). I will also take photographs and brief field notes documenting behavior such as scavenging, flocking, or ignoring possible food sources. To contextualize my findings, I will connect them to ecological concepts such as niche breadth, urban ecology, and optimal foraging theory discussed in lecture and lab. I may supplement observations with recent studies on crow adaptation to urban environments.

Presentation Style:

I plan to present my project as a short video (~10 minutes) incorporating narration, photos, short clips of crows feeding, and clear explanation of ecological concepts for a general undergraduate audience.